

61 Saul

Israel's first king, who began small in his own eyes and ended at war with God's word.

Saul was a tall, handsome young man from the small tribe of Benjamin. He went out looking for his father's lost donkeys and came home anointed as king. Israel had asked for "a king to judge us like all the nations" (1 Samuel 8:5), and Saul looked the part. He started well, rescuing a besieged town and fighting the Philistines all his days. But again and again he put his own plans above God's clear commands. He offered a sacrifice he was told to wait for. He spared what he was told to destroy. Then jealousy of David ate away at him. His story is a sober study in how a gifted leader can lose his way one small disobedience at a time.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Sha'ul</i> , "asked for"
Family	Son of Kish, of Benjamin; wife Ahinoam (1 Samuel 9:1; 14:50)
Children	Jonathan, Ish-bosheth and others; Merab, Michal (1 Samuel 14:49)
Reign	c. 1050–1010 BC; "forty years" (Acts 13:21)
Key places	Gibeah, Mizpeh, Gilgal, Jabesh-gilead, Endor, Mount Gilboa
Key people	Samuel, Jonathan, David, Michal, Abner his commander
New Testament	Acts 13:21–22

"Behold, to obey is better than sacrifice, and to hearken than the fat of rams."

1 Samuel 15:22, KJV

The life of Saul

Dates are approximate. The Hebrew of 1 Samuel 13:1 is unclear, so Saul's age at his crowning is unknown.

c. 1050 BC <i>Young man</i>	● Anointed in secret Looking for his father's lost donkeys, Saul meets Samuel, who anoints him with oil. <i>1 Samuel 9:1-10:16</i>
c. 1050 BC <i>Start of reign</i>	● Chosen by lot At Mizpeh the lot falls on Saul. He is found hiding "among the stuff." <i>1 Samuel 10:17-27</i>
Early reign	● Rescues Jabesh-gilead Nahash the Ammonite threatens the town. The Spirit of God comes on Saul, and he rallies Israel to save it. <i>1 Samuel 11:1-15</i>
Early reign	● Offers the sacrifice himself Facing the Philistines, Saul tires of waiting for Samuel and offers the burnt offering himself. His kingdom will not continue. <i>1 Samuel 13:5-14</i>
Later	● Spares Agag Saul spares Agag and the best animals. Because he rejected the LORD's word, the LORD rejects him as king. <i>1 Samuel 15:1-35</i>
Middle years	● David arrives The Spirit leaves Saul, and an evil spirit troubles him. David plays the harp for him, kills Goliath, and wins the women's praise. <i>1 Samuel 16:14-18:9</i>
Last years	● Hunts David Saul throws his spear at David and chases him through the wilderness. Twice David spares Saul's life. <i>1 Samuel 18:10-26:25</i>
c. 1010 BC <i>End of reign</i>	● Endor and Gilboa With God silent, Saul consults a medium at Endor. On Mount Gilboa his sons die, and he falls on his own sword. <i>1 Samuel 28:3-25; 31:1-13</i>

Key activities

1 Samuel 31 says Saul fell on his own sword. In 2 Samuel 1 an Amalekite claims he finished Saul off. Many readers think the Amalekite lied, hoping for a reward from David.

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- I Began humbly.** He called Benjamin the smallest tribe and hid when the lot fell on him. *1 Samuel 9:21; 10:21-22*

 - 2 Prophesied.** God gave him "another heart," and he prophesied among the prophets. *1 Samuel 10:9-12*

 - 3 Saved Jabesh-gilead.** He summoned the tribes, routed Ammon, and spared those who had mocked him. *1 Samuel 11:5-13*

 - 4 Ran ahead of God.** He offered the burnt offering instead of waiting for Samuel. *1 Samuel 13:8-14*

 - 5 Made a rash oath.** He forbade his army to eat and nearly put Jonathan to death. *1 Samuel 14:24-45*

 - 6 Fought Israel's enemies.** There was sore war with the Philistines all his days. *1 Samuel 14:47-52*

 - 7 Spared what God condemned.** He kept Agag and the best flocks, yet claimed he had obeyed. *1 Samuel 15:7-21*

 - 8 Fed his jealousy.** Saul "eyed David from that day and forward." *1 Samuel 18:6-11; 19:9-10*

 - 9 Killed the priests of Nob.** Doeg put to death eighty-five priests at his command. *1 Samuel 22:9-19*

 - 10 Admitted his wrong, briefly.** "I have played the fool, and have erred exceedingly." *1 Samuel 24:16-22; 26:21*

 - II Sought a medium.** He had banned mediums, but in fear he went to one at Endor. *1 Samuel 28:3-19*

 - 12 Died on Gilboa.** Wounded, he fell on his sword; Jabesh-gilead buried him. *1 Samuel 31:1-13*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Saul.

Old Testament

1 Samuel 8–31	The main account, from the request for a king to his death
2 Samuel 1:17–27	David's lament: "how are the mighty fallen!"
2 Samuel 21:1–14	Famine for his killing of the Gibeonites
1 Samuel 28:11–19	"Samuel" at Endor; Christians differ on what appeared
1 Chronicles 10:1–14	He died for unfaithfulness and consulting a medium
Echo: Deuteronomy 17:14–20	What Israel's king should be

New Testament

Acts 13:21–22	"Saul the son of Cis" reigned forty years, then removed
Echo: Philippians 3:5	Paul, also Saul, of the tribe of Benjamin
Echo: Luke 6:46	Calling Jesus "Lord" yet not doing what he says

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What reasons did Saul give for offering the sacrifice and for sparing Agag (1 Samuel 13:11–12; 15:15, 20–21)?
2. *Understand:* Samuel said "to obey is better than sacrifice." Why might religious activity be easier than obedience?
3. *Apply:* Saul's jealousy began with a song about someone else's success. Whose success is hard for you to celebrate right now?
4. *Apply:* Saul acted under pressure instead of waiting. Where are you tempted to rush ahead of God this week?